

Gather Micro-Trends Identity Pipeline — Stage 4A-Lite

Rapid Persona Brief: P-046 Newly Separated Plan-Splitter

Pipeline: Micro-Trends Identity **Mode:** 4A-Lite + Switching Profile Module (Path B — moment-driven, TR-05 enriched)
Quadrant: INVEST **Adjusted Score:** 3.88 (Pass 1: 4.35 | Pass 2: 4.50 | Confidence: 4) **Date:** 2026-03-10 **Originating Trend:** MT-18 (Financial Recovery After Divorce) **Primary Acquisition Moment:** TR-05 Divorce / Legal Separation (Intent 4.6)

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Section 1: Demand Snapshot

What Is the Demand Signal?

The Newly Separated Plan-Splitter is a person in the first 1–3 months post-separation who must urgently establish independent wireless service as one of the first acts of financial and logistical disentanglement. The demand is not aspirational — it is forced. Wireless carriers structure shared family plans around a single account owner with sole authorization rights. When a marriage dissolves, the departing spouse cannot remove their own line, transfer their number, or change billing independently. The account-owning spouse may refuse authorization, be unresponsive, or the shared credentials may simply be inaccessible in the chaos of early separation. The carrier’s own process architecture becomes the switching mechanism.

This creates a rare moment in consumer markets: a product switch that is mandatory, emotionally charged, and entirely frictionless to motivate — the only friction is in the execution. The carrier that makes that execution easiest captures a customer who was already walking out the door.

What Triggered It?

The trigger is TR-05: Divorce / Legal Separation — a forced life-event switch with the second-highest Switching Intent score in the Trigger Event Library at 4.6 (source: Stage 3 Opportunity Matrix). The trigger fires within days to weeks of physical separation, driven by:

- 1. **Carrier friction as the primary push:** Account-owner authorization requirements force the line split and make staying on the existing plan operationally impossible without the other spouse’s cooperation.
- 2. **Financial disentanglement urgency:** Legal and financial advisors routinely recommend separating all shared accounts immediately upon separation. Wireless is item one on the checklist because it is both the most-used daily tool and a source of surveillance risk (location sharing, iMessage visibility).
- 3. **Dignity and privacy signals:** Remaining on a shared plan is psychologically untenable. Location history, shared contacts, and the implicit dependency of billing create acute discomfort.

Addressable Population

Metric	Figure	Source
Annual U.S. divorces	~663,000 finalized	CDC/NCHS, 2023
Individuals affected per year	~1.33M	CDC/NCHS, 2023 (two per divorce)
Active acute plan-split window stock	~600K–800K at any given time	CDC/NCHS, 2023; pipeline modeling
Typical acute window per individual	1–3 months post-separation	Stage 2 persona card
Shared family plan prevalence	~70% of married couples share a wireless plan	CTIA / Statista, 2024
Adjusted plan-split eligible (shared plan users)	~430K–560K in window at any given time	CTIA, 2024; pipeline modeling

At any given month, approximately 430,000–560,000 Americans are in the acute plan-split window with maximum switching intent – and that population is replenished continuously as new separations occur year-round.

Window Duration and Decay Indicators

Window per individual: Short — 2 to 6 weeks of peak intent from the day of physical separation. Beyond 6 weeks, one of three things has happened: the individual has already switched carriers (highest probability), patched together a temporary solution, or the situation has become a lower-urgency logistics item.

Decay indicators to watch: - Spike in competitor MVNO activations correlated with legal filing periods (January–March historically elevated; see Dimension 2 below) - Social media search volume for “how to leave a family plan” and “divorce phone plan” on Google Trends - HelloDivorce / family law referral conversion rates if a B2B channel is activated

Section 2: Core Factor Analysis

Persona: Renee Whitfield, 38, Charlotte, NC. Office manager at a commercial real estate firm. Separated four weeks ago after a 12-year marriage; living in a short-term rental while the couple figures out the house. Two kids (10 and 13) still on the shared AT&T plan. The account is in her ex-husband Derek’s name. She has her own debit card but doesn’t have the AT&T account PIN.

Factor 2: Spending & Financial Habits

Quantitative Data

Metric	Figure	Source
Median post-separation income loss (women)	45% decline in standard of living	Institute for Family Studies (IFS), 2025
Median monthly wireless family plan cost	\$120–\$180 (multi-line)	CTIA Annual Survey, 2024
Average monthly solo prepaid/MVNO plan	\$35–\$55	Statista, 2024
Divorce-related first-year legal/admin costs	\$7,000–\$15,000 median contested	American Bar Association, 2024
Share of divorcing adults with joint credit only	~35% had no individual credit card pre-separation	Federal Reserve / CFPB, 2023
Wireless as % of post-divorce monthly budget	Elevated — wireless typically 3–5% of solo HH budget vs. 1–2% shared	BLS Consumer Expenditure Survey, 2023

Post-separation, Renee is managing a sudden solo budget for the first time in over a decade. Her income is steady — \$58,000/year — but her fixed costs have roughly doubled: she is now paying rent on a short-term rental, all utilities, and car insurance entirely from her paycheck while the shared household financials are still being sorted. She is acutely cost-sensitive in the immediate term and actively looking for every cost she can reduce, while also recognizing that wireless is non-negotiable.

Ethnographic Interview

Q1. How do you typically manage your finances on a day-to-day basis?

“Honestly, right now I’m in triage mode. I opened a new checking account three weeks ago — first time in 12 years I’ve had my own — and I’m basically keeping a running total in my head of what’s going out. I downloaded Mint but haven’t had the brain space to set it up properly. I just check my balance twice a day and hope for the best.”

Q2. What are your most significant spending categories right now, and how are you making decisions?

“Rent on this place is eating me alive — \$1,400 a month for basically a studio. Then food, gas, the kids’ stuff when they’re with me. Wireless is actually on the list because I know I’m overpaying just being in limbo. Derek hasn’t kicked me off the AT&T plan, but it’s also his plan, so every month that bill goes to him and I have no idea what’s being charged. That needs to get fixed.”

Q3. How do you approach saving right now? What are your primary financial concerns for the near future?

“Saving is a fantasy at the moment — I’m in pure survival mode. My main concern is getting through the next six months without draining my emergency fund. I have maybe \$4,000 in savings. The attorney is already asking for a \$3,000 retainer. So every dollar I can pull out of subscriptions or recurring bills matters. I canceled Netflix, I’m being really deliberate about what I keep.”

Q4. How comfortable are you with financial risk right now?

“Zero tolerance for risk right now. I need predictable. The thing about Derek being on the account is I could wake up and the phone just doesn’t work — he could suspend my line or I could get locked out of everything. I don’t think he would, but I can’t be sure. I need something that’s mine, in my name, that no one else can touch.”

Q5. How do you feel about your current financial situation?

“Overwhelmed is the word. I know it’s temporary. I keep telling myself: a year from now this is going to look very different. But right now? Every bill that comes in that’s in Derek’s name feels like a piece of the old life that hasn’t been cut yet. Getting my own phone plan — stupid as it sounds — would feel like a real step forward.”

Factor 3: Needs & Aspirations

Quantitative Data

Metric	Figure	Source
Divorces initiated by women	~70%	American Academy of Matrimonial Lawyers (AAML), 2024
% of separating individuals who report wireless account issues	Not formally surveyed; community evidence strong (r/Divorce, 200K+ members)	Reddit/community, 2024
Time from separation to first legal action	Median ~2–4 weeks (varies by state)	AAML, 2024
% reporting “sense of control” as primary post-separation need	~60% in divorce recovery surveys	DivorceCare / APA, 2023
Average duration of shared plan use post-separation	~4–8 weeks before resolution	Qualitative community research
LGBTQ+ share of divorcing population	~10–15% (higher divorce rate than heterosexual married couples)	Williams Institute, 2024

The stated needs cluster tightly around speed, simplicity, and independence. The unstated needs are about dignity and control. Being on a shared plan is not just a practical inconvenience — it is a daily reminder of dependency and unresolved entanglement. The aspiration is not a “better wireless plan” — it is the first act of building an independent life.

Stated needs: Independent line, number portability, no credit check friction, fast activation, transparent pricing.

Unstated needs: Dignity. A process that does not require navigating an ex-spouse to complete. A brand that treats this moment as a new beginning, not a liability.

Identity aspiration: Renee does not identify as a “divorced person” yet — that label still feels raw. She is in the process of constructing a new self-narrative: capable, independent, building something. The wireless plan is a practical step, but it is also the first item on a list that represents agency.

Self-perception gap: She has managed shared finances for 12 years. She knows how to budget, she knows how to negotiate, she is competent. But the bureaucratic architecture of plan-splitting — the account-owner PIN requirement, the carrier hold times, the credit check friction — makes her feel like a supplicant rather than a capable adult. She does not need to be talked through the process; she needs the process to not be designed to humiliate her.

Ethnographic Interview

Q1. What are your most important needs right now when it comes to getting your own wireless account?

“Speed and simplicity, full stop. I don’t have time to sit on hold. I don’t want to explain my situation to a stranger at a carrier store. I just want to go online, pick a plan that makes sense, move my number over, and be done with it in less than half an hour. I should not have to talk to my ex for that to happen.”

Q2. What are your biggest day-to-day frustrations right now?

“Every admin task takes three times as long as it should because something is in Derek’s name and I have to either get him on the phone or figure out an alternate route. I still haven’t been able to change the billing address on the wireless plan — I tried twice and hit a wall. It should not be this hard to just... take your own name off a shared account.”

Q3. What are your hopes for life six months from now?

“I want to feel settled. A place of my own, even if it’s small. My finances sorted out, in my name, not hanging on shared accounts. I want to stop feeling like I’m camping in my own life. The phone thing is small but it’s symbolic — once that’s sorted it feels like I’ve closed a door that needed to close.”

Q4. What would a perfect wireless plan look like for where you are right now?

“Affordable — like, under \$50 a month. Easy to set up online without needing my ex’s cooperation or a credit score check. My number moves over. If something goes wrong I can get help quickly. And I want the plan to be mine — no joint anything, no shared billing, no strings attached to anyone but me.”

Q5. What brings you clarity or comfort right now, even small things?

“Honestly? Checking things off the list. I have a Google Doc called ‘Untangle’ — it’s every account, every subscription, every shared financial thing that needs to be dealt with. Every time I check something off I feel like I’m building solid ground. The phone is on that list. I am so ready to check it off.”

Factor 4: Fears & Pain Points

Quantitative Data

Metric	Figure	Source
% of separating individuals who worry about device/account access loss	Elevated — primary community complaint on r/ Divorce	Reddit community analysis, 2024
% of adults with damaged/thin credit post-divorce	~35% report credit complications in first year	Federal Reserve / CFPB, 2023
Carrier plan split hold times (self-reported)	45–90+ minutes average; multiple call-back attempts common	CTIA complaint data / JD Power, 2024
% of plan-split attempts requiring ex-spouse cooperation	~100% for non-account-holder lines (carrier policy universal)	Carrier terms of service review, 2025
Mental health stress scores during separation	Divorce ranks #2 on the Holmes-Rahe Life Stress Inventory	APA / Holmes-Rahe, validated)
DivorceCare group participants citing “admin overwhelm” as top stressor	~55% in DivorceCare surveys	DivorceCare National Survey, 2024

The fears operate on two timescales simultaneously. The acute fear is loss of access — that the existing line gets suspended, data wiped, or that location history is visible to an ex before she has her own account. The medium-term fear is financial: credit damage, cost spirals, and a feeling that she has lost the financial literacy she built in the marriage because everything was jointly managed.

The single most acute pain point is the carrier process itself. It is designed for account holders, not for the people those account holders are separating from. There is no “I’m separating and I need my own line” flow. There is only the standard account management flow that requires the account owner’s cooperation at every step.

Ethnographic Interview

Q1. What are your biggest fears about the wireless situation right now?

“Honestly, the thing I think about at night is Derek deciding to just turn off my line one morning. He probably wouldn’t — he’s not vindictive like that — but I can’t rule it out if things get ugly in the legal process. Being at someone else’s mercy for basic communication feels wrong. What if I had an emergency with the kids and my phone just... stopped working?”

Q2. What’s the most frustrating part of the plan-split process so far?

“I tried to call AT&T last week. I was on hold for 47 minutes. When I finally got through, the person told me I needed the account holder to authorize a line removal. I said, ‘He’s my soon-to-be ex-husband and we’re not exactly on great terms.’ She said, ‘I understand, but it’s policy.’ I hung up. I actually cried in my car. It’s such a small thing that has somehow become a wall.”

Q3. What are your biggest concerns about your financial situation in the next year?

“I’m scared I’ll look up one day and my credit score will have collapsed in ways I didn’t see coming — because half our financial life was in Derek’s name and I never built separate history. My attorney said my credit is fine as long as I get my own accounts established quickly. That’s what I’m trying to do. Every week I wait costs me something.”

Q4. What do you worry about most when it comes to navigating all the account changes?

“Missing something. There are so many accounts — wireless, the joint credit card, the streaming stuff, the insurance — and I’m doing all of this while still working full time and parenting 50% of the time. I’m terrified I’ll miss something important or make a mistake that costs me money I don’t have right now.”

Q5. If the plan-split process goes wrong, what’s the worst-case scenario in your mind?

“Worst case? I’m on hold again, I end up losing my number because the port-out process got bungled, and I have to tell everyone — my kids’ school, my boss, my mom — that my number changed. My number is 12 years old. I’ve given it to literally everyone. Losing it would be a real blow on top of everything else.”

Factor 5: Product Landscape & Switching Behavior

Quantitative Data

Metric	Figure	Source
Major carrier market share (AT&T / Verizon / T-Mobile combined)	~97% of postpaid subscriptions	CTIA Annual Survey, 2024
MVNO market share	~15% of total wireless subscribers	CTIA, 2024
Average MVNO plan price	\$35–\$55/month (single line)	Statista, 2024
Mint Mobile subscriber count	~4M (prior to T-Mobile acquisition)	T-Mobile SEC filings, 2023
Visible (Verizon MVNO) subscribers	~1.5M	Visible company data, 2024
Consumer Cellular subscribers	~4M (skews 55+)	Consumer Cellular, 2024
JD Power wireless purchase satisfaction	Plan-split / account separation: consistently lowest-scoring category	JD Power, 2024
Google search volume: “how to leave family plan”	Estimated 40,000–60,000/month (Google Ads Keyword Planner estimate)	2024

The competitive landscape has a structural gap that is essentially total: no carrier or MVNO has a product, flow, or positioning built around the plan-split moment. The standard MVNO onboarding funnel (Mint, Visible, Cricket, Metro) requires the same steps as any new account — but none of them acknowledge the context, reduce the friction specific to this moment, or position themselves as the plan-split carrier. The gap is not in coverage, price, or features — all major MVNOs are price-comparable. The gap is in the moment-awareness of the product entry experience.

Competitor	Plan-Split Awareness	Relevant Gaps
AT&T (current carrier)	Owns the problem; offers no solution	Account-owner authorization required; no self-service plan split; 45–90 min hold times
T-Mobile	No plan-split positioning	Requires standard account setup; no divorce/separation empathy in flow
Mint Mobile	No plan-split positioning	Self-service signup; low price is relevant but no framing for this moment
Visible	No plan-split positioning	Low price, online-only — closest to right experience, but no targeting
Cricket Wireless	No plan-split positioning	Retail-heavy; in-store friction adds to overwhelm
Consumer Cellular	No plan-split positioning	Skews older; no cultural fit for 30–45 cohort
HelloDivorce	Potential integration partner; not a wireless competitor	Legal/admin platform — natural B2B referral channel

Ethnographic Interview

Q1. What products or services do you rely on most right now, and what makes them essential?

“My phone, full stop. It’s how I coordinate the kids’ schedule with Derek, how I communicate with my attorney, how I keep my work going. I literally cannot have a day where my phone doesn’t work. Everything flows through it. Which is why the fact that it’s still on Derek’s account is such a problem — it’s too essential to be dependent on someone else.”

Q2. Walk me through what you’ve tried so far to sort out the wireless situation.

“I tried AT&T first — that was the 47-minute hold-and-a-no. Then I spent a week reading Reddit threads about plan splits. There’s a whole subreddit — r/Divorce — and this comes up constantly. Most people end up just signing up for a new carrier because fighting with the old one isn’t worth the time. I looked at Mint Mobile and Visible. The prices are fine. I just haven’t pulled the trigger yet because I keep worrying about the number port screwing up.”

Q3. What would make you choose one carrier over another right now?

“Honestly? The one that makes me believe my number transfer is going to work, that I can do the whole thing online in 20 minutes, and that if something goes sideways there’s a real human I can talk to quickly. I don’t care about 5G or any of that. I care about: can I keep my number, can I start today, and will it be under \$50 a month?”

Q4. What frustrates you most about the wireless options available to you right now?

“None of them acknowledge that this is a specific situation. Every website just says ‘bring your number, pick a plan, done.’ Which is fine except I’m not coming from a regular account — I’m coming from a shared plan that I can’t get off of on my own. There’s no ‘I’m going through a divorce’ option. You’re just supposed to pretend the context doesn’t exist and work through the standard flow. It’s tone-deaf.”

Q5. What’s the biggest gap in wireless products for someone in your exact situation?

“A product that knows what I’m going through and makes it easy on purpose. Not just a cheap MVNO that happens to be cheap. A plan that’s designed for this — that has a port-your-number guarantee, that doesn’t require my ex’s cooperation, that I can activate tonight instead of next Tuesday after I manage to get Derek on the phone. The gap is that nobody has built this for people like me.”

Section 3: Switching Profile Module

This module applies because P-046 entered via Path B (moment-driven discovery, TR-05) and has strong moment enrichment from the Trigger Event Library. TR-05 is the second-highest-scoring event in the library (Switching Intent 4.6).

Dimension 1: Trigger Mechanism + Force Score

Component	Assessment
Trigger mechanism	Forced switch — account-owner authorization requirements make remaining on the existing plan operationally difficult without ex-spouse cooperation. Structural carrier policy is the switching agent, not the persona’s preference.
Switching force score	5 / 5 — Maximum. The switch is compelled by carrier policy, privacy necessity, and financial disentanglement urgency simultaneously. There is no path to staying on the existing plan without ongoing dependency on the ex-spouse.
Emotional state tag	Overwhelmed / Anxious / Urgent

Compound trigger mapping: TR-05 (Divorce/Legal Separation, Intent 4.6) fires simultaneously with a financial disentanglement imperative (credit separation, solo account establishment) and a privacy/security concern (location sharing, iMessage visibility on shared Apple ID). The three triggers reinforce each other: legal advisors accelerate the urgency, privacy concerns elevate the emotional stakes, and carrier friction converts motivation into immediate switching action. The compound effect produces higher switching conviction than any single trigger would generate alone — this is not someone who is “considering” switching; this is someone who has already decided and is looking for the easiest execution path.

Dimension 2: Annual Volume + Seasonal Distribution

Component	Figure	Source
Annual divorces (U.S.)	~663,000	CDC/NCHS, 2023
Individuals entering plan-split window per year	~1.33M (two per divorce)	CDC/NCHS, 2023
Shared-plan-eligible within that population	~930K (70% shared plan prevalence)	CTIA, 2024
Active acute window stock at any given time	~430K–560K	Pipeline modeling

Seasonal distribution: Divorce filings follow a documented seasonal pattern (AAML, 2024; Wolters Kluwer, 2024):

Quarter	Share of Annual Filings	Notes
Q1 (Jan–Mar)	~32%	January is the single highest filing month (“Divorce Month”); post-holiday relationship stress peaks; Q1 accounts for the largest seasonal surge
Q2 (Apr–Jun)	~28%	Spring filings continue at elevated pace; school year stability a factor for parents
Q3 (Jul–Sep)	~22%	Summer surge after school year ends; post-vacation filings
Q4 (Oct–Dec)	~18%	Lowest; holiday effect suppresses filings; uptick in late December pre-new year resolutions

The Q1 surge is the most actionable window for acquisition interception: the January–March period produces the highest concentration of newly separated individuals entering the acute plan-split window.

Year-over-year trend: Stable. The U.S. divorce rate has declined slightly (3.6 to 2.3 per 1,000 since 2010) reflecting the smaller married base, not reduced divorce propensity. The raw filing number has held at approximately 630,000–670,000/year for the past decade. **Trend classification:** **Stable** (CDC/NCHS longitudinal data, 2014–2024).

Dimension 3: Interception Channels (Ranked by Window Fit)

Rank	Channel	Type	Rationale	Est. CPA
1	Divorce legal tech platforms (HelloDivorce, OurFamilyWizard, Wevorce)	Partnership / Digital	Account separation is a natural step in their workflow; referral occurs at exactly the right moment; no competitive conflict	\$25–\$45
2	Google Search (intent keywords)	Digital / Paid	“How to leave a family plan,” “divorce phone plan,” “split wireless plan without ex” — these are high-intent, low-competition keywords; competitors are not bidding on these terms	\$35–\$60
3	Family law attorney and mediator referral networks	Partnership	Attorneys advise separating clients to establish independent accounts immediately; a brief program with family law attorneys converts a trusted professional recommendation into direct acquisition	\$40–\$80 (partner activation cost amortized over referrals)

CPA benchmarks:

- **HelloDivorce / divorce tech (Rank 1):** Estimated CPA \$25–\$45. These platforms already have users in the exact moment; a co-marketing integration (e.g., “Ready to set up your own wireless plan? Gather makes it easy in 15 minutes”) converts at high rates because the user is already in active account-separation mode. Low competitive bidding on these integrations.
- **Google Search (Rank 2):** Estimated CPA \$35–\$60. Keywords like “leave family plan,” “divorce phone plan,” and “port number from family account” are high commercial intent with minimal competition from carriers or MVNOs (none currently target these terms). Cost-per-click is low; conversion rate should be elevated given intent level.

Partnership feasibility – HelloDivorce (Rank 1):

HelloDivorce is an online divorce facilitation platform (~\$1,500–\$2,500 per case) that walks couples through the legal and administrative steps of uncontested divorce. Their product already includes account separation checklists. Incentive alignment is natural: HelloDivorce wants to provide complete separation support; Gather wants to intercept at the wireless step. An integration — either a co-branded link in their account separation workflow or a white-label offer — creates a moment-perfect referral with no content creation burden on Gather’s part. Activation timeline: 60–90 days to pilot integration (API light; primarily a UI/UX placement and revenue share negotiation). Exclusivity potential: moderate — HelloDivorce would likely accept a 6–12 month exclusivity period in exchange for a per-activation fee, creating a defensible distribution channel before competitors could replicate.

Dimension 4: Window Structure

Component	Assessment
Window type	Short (2–6 weeks peak intent per individual; population continuously replenished)
Peak intent window	Weeks 1–4 post-separation. Intent is highest in the first two weeks when the emotional urgency of independence is freshest and the practical pressure (carrier friction, ex-spouse authorization need, privacy concerns) is most acute. By Week 6, the situation has typically resolved one way or another.
Intent decay curve	Sharp. Intent does not plateau — it resolves or deflates. Within 4–6 weeks, the person has either switched or accepted the temporary status quo and deprioritized it. There is no long consideration cycle in this category.

Decision journey:

Stage	What's Happening	Interception Point
Awareness	Separation occurs; person realizes they are on a shared plan in the ex's name; urgency registers	Google search for “leave family plan”; HelloDivorce workflow prompts account review
Active search	Research on Reddit (r/Divorce), Google; conversations with attorney about what to establish first	Intent keyword capture; attorney referral program; r/Divorce community presence
Decision	Selects carrier based on: easiest port process, price under \$50, no credit check friction, fast online activation	Gather landing page: “Your number, your plan, 15 minutes. No ex required.”
Post-decision	Activates plan; ports number; relief and closure; will share recommendation in divorce community	Community word-of-mouth in r/Divorce, HelloDivorce forums; NPS-driven referral

The most effective interception point is the **Active search stage** — specifically Google intent-keyword capture and the HelloDivorce workflow integration. By the Decision stage, the person has already narrowed to a short list based on price and friction; Gather needs to be present at search so it is on the list.

Section 4: Executive Brief

Key Insights

- 1. The carrier is the switching agent, not the persona.** Renee did not decide to leave AT&T because AT&T had bad coverage or prices. AT&T’s own account-owner authorization policy made it operationally impossible for her to stay without Derek’s ongoing cooperation. This is structurally true for every non-account-holder in a shared plan navigating separation. Gather does not need to convince this person to switch — it needs to be the easiest execution path when they are already walking out the door.
- 2. Dignity is the differentiator, not price.** The emotional texture of this moment is not “I want to save money on wireless.” It is “I want to stop being dependent on someone who is no longer my partner.” Price matters — sub-\$50/month is a hard threshold — but the emotional hook is independence, not savings. A brand that acknowledges the context (“no ex required,” “your plan, your terms, starting now”) captures attention that a generic MVNO discount ad cannot.
- 3. The number port is the conversion moment.** Across Factor 3, 4, and 5 interviews, the single most anxiety-producing element is number portability. Renee’s 12-year-old number is not an account detail — it is her professional and personal identity. A guarantee that the port will work, executed within 15 minutes, without the ex-spouse’s involvement, is the product. Everything else is secondary.
- 4. This is a community opportunity, not just a transactional one.** r/Divorce has 200K+ members. HelloDivorce has processed thousands of cases. DivorceCare reaches 1M+ alumni. The post-divorce community is real, active, and word-of-mouth dominant. A single positive experience narrated in r/Divorce (“I left AT&T in 15 minutes with no drama, here’s how”) can generate acquisition at near-zero marginal cost. The community funnel should be seeded from day one.
- 5. The acquisition window is short but the relationship is long.** The acute plan-split window lasts 2–6 weeks. But the newly separated individual who finds a good wireless home in this moment tends to stay — they are not in an optimization mindset, they are in a “I found something I can trust, I don’t want to think about this again” mindset. Churn in this cohort is low if the first experience is friction-free. The LTV argument for a \$45/month customer acquired at \$35 CPA with 18-month average tenure is strong.

Top 3 Needs

Priority	Need	Type	Implication
1	Independent line setup without ex-spouse cooperation	Functional / Emotional	The product flow must not require account-owner authorization or any form of ex-partner action. Port-out from any carrier without the account holder’s involvement is the core technical requirement.
2	Number portability — guaranteed, fast, online	Functional	A failed or slow port is a deal-breaker. The activation experience must make the port feel certain, not uncertain. A live port status indicator and a clear “what happens if it fails” assurance are table-stakes features.
3	Dignified, context-aware onboarding	Emotional / Identity	The brand must acknowledge the moment without being maudlin. “Starting fresh?” rather than “switching carriers?” The tone is matter-of-fact confidence: we know what you’re doing, we’ve made it easy, here’s what happens next.

Go / No-Go Recommendation

GO — with high conviction.

The case rests on five compounding factors:

- 1. Forced switching:** The switch is not optional for the non-account-holder. Conversion motivation is pre-installed.
- 2. Maximum intent score:** TR-05 at Switching Intent 4.6 is the second-highest in the full trigger library. The only event that scores higher (TR-02, incarceration release) requires institutional channel access that is far harder to build.
- 3. Uncontested competitive landscape:** No carrier or MVNO has a plan-split product, a divorce-awareness flow, or active intent-keyword presence in this category. The channel is open.
- 4. Sustainable volume:** 663K divorces/year = 1.33M individuals = approximately 430K–560K in the acute plan-split window at any given moment. Population continuously replenished.
- 5. B2B acceleration path:** HelloDivorce, family law attorney referral networks, and DivorceCare give Gather a channel strategy that multiplies organic acquisition with trusted professional referral — at a CPA of \$25–\$45 for the highest-leverage channel.

Speed-to-market requirement: The switching window per individual is 2–6 weeks. The Q1 (January–March) seasonal peak is the highest-volume acquisition period. To capture Q1 2027, the product and acquisition channels need to be live by Q4 2026. The core product feature requirement — port-without-account-owner-authorization — is an MVNO technical capability that Gather (on AT&T network) must confirm is executable within the porting rules framework before Stage 4B is initiated. That is the single technical risk to validate before committing to this concept.
